

Ethics and the Golden Mean



Ignoring advice to take a middle course between sea and sky, Icarus was tempted to fly too high; the heat of the sun melted the wax of his wings and he fell to his death.

Socrates was largely concerned with refining definitions of such things as virtues, in an attempt to discover their essential quality – a quest that continued in the moral philosophy of Plato and Aristotle. But although they apparently sought an absolute definition, they were wary of focusing it too narrowly, preferring to think of a sort of scale of degrees of each virtue. The idea of moderation figured largely in Greek thought from earliest times,

encapsulated in the maxim 'nothing in excess', and exemplified in the ancient myth of Icarus.

Moderation was an especially important element of Aristotle's ethics. He envisaged the spectrum of a virtue not as ranging from extremes of 'good' to 'bad', but with an optimal value in the middle of the scale – the so-called Golden Mean. For example, courage is considered a virtue, but when taken to one extreme becomes recklessness and at the other extreme cowardice, both of which are undesirable traits; similarly, justice can be seen to have extremes of severity and leniency.